REGIONAL CONFLICTS

ALTHOUGH MOST CONFLICTS since 1945 have been largely restricted to land warfare, the "war in peace" has nonetheless featured some major regional naval engagements. Significant naval actions occured, for example, around the troubled Middle Eastern region during the Arab-Israeli wars of the 1960s and 70s, and in the waters around the Indian subcontinent during the later decade. The navies involved in these engagements have not been the world's largest by any means, but in many cases they were pioneers in testing out modern ship-versus-ship weapon systems and electronic countermeasures in actual combat situations. In this capacity they often had a formative role in the development of naval weaponry by the major Western and Soviet bloc powers. The diversity of postwar regional naval engagements has also been impressive, and has ranged from gunboat missile actions through to well-organized suicide bombings and carrier aircraft attacks. Sheer cost has limited the capacity of many regional powers to maintain navies in recent years, but investment in modern weapons technology has enabled them to remain a potent threat to far larger forces.

ARAB-ISRAELI WARS

SINKING OF THE EILAT



Date October 21, 1967
Forces Israelis: 1 destroyer; Egyptians: 2 missile boats
Losses Israelis: 1 destroyer; Egyptians: none

Location Off Egyptian coastline, near Port Said

Prior to her sale to Israel in 1955, the *Eilat* had seen service in World War II as the British Z-Class destroyer HMS *Zealous*. Renamed *Eilat*, she enjoyed a long operational record, including the sinking of two Egyptian vessels.

On October 21, 1967, the *Eilat* was on a routine patrol of the Sinai coastline, which took her some 15 miles (25 km) from the Egyptian city of Port Said, when she suddenly came under attack from an Egyptian Komar-class missile boat. The boat fired a Russian-built SS-N-2 Styx anti-ship missile that struck the *Eilat*, destroying her communications and powerplant. The *Eilat* was attacked again 90 minutes later, receiving another missile strike that caused her magazine to detonate. The crew abandoned ship, but many were wounded in the water when one of the ship's depth charges exploded. A total of 47 Israeli sailors were killed.

The *Eilat* was the first ship to be sunk in battle by a ship-launched anti-ship missile. It was a huge blow to the Israeli navy and led to a major review of Israeli naval strategy. The resulting focus on fast, missile-armed boats and missile countermeasures would reap major benefits for the Israeli navy six years later at Latakia.

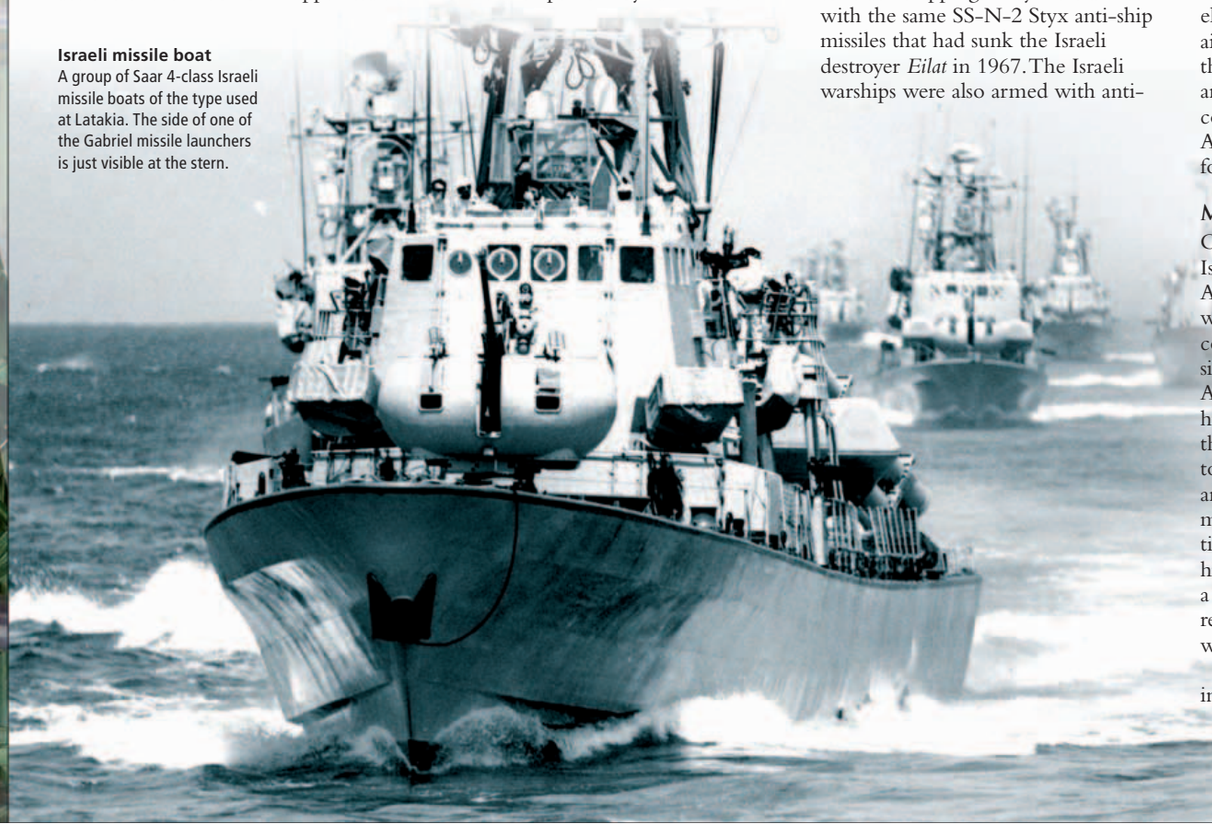


Styx anti-ship missile
A fast missile boat launches a Soviet SS-N-2 Styx missile of the type that sunk the Israeli destroyer INS *Eilat*.

THE BATTLE OF LATAKIA

The battle of Latakia was a milestone in postwar naval engagements—never before had anti-ship missiles and missile-jamming technology been pitted against one another in open combat. The context of the battle was the opening actions of the 1973 Yom Kippur War.

On October 6, Egyptian forces launched a surprise eastward thrust across the Suez Canal against Israeli forces in the Sinai. Syria made a simultaneous attack from the north across the Golan Heights. In an attempt to check the potential threat to Israeli ships from Syrian missile boats, Israeli commanders decided to mount a preemptive naval strike, sending six Saar-class corvettes to draw the Syrian missile boats out of their harbor at Latakia and destroy them. The Syrian vessels posed a realistic threat to Israeli shipping. They were armed with the same SS-N-2 Styx anti-ship missiles that had sunk the Israeli destroyer *Eilat* in 1967. The Israeli warships were also armed with anti-ship missiles, but since the Israeli Gabriel—which had yet to be used in battle—had only half the range of the Styx, the crews would have to rely on newly developed, and still unproven, electronic countermeasures (ECM). These consisted of two principal elements: chaff dispensers to fill the air with metallic strips, clouding the incoming missile's target picture; and jamming systems designed to confuse the missile's tracking system. At Latakia both systems would be tested for the first time against real threats.



Israeli missile boat
A group of Saar 4-class Israeli missile boats of the type used at Latakia. The side of one of the Gabriel missile launchers is just visible at the stern.

MISSILE DUEL

Contact was made quickly as the six Israeli missile boats approached Latakia. An offshore Syrian P-4 torpedo boat was picked up on radar, and the Israeli corvette *Hanit* moved to engage her, sinking the boat with long-range gunfire. Assuming that the Syrian torpedo boat had reported their presence off Latakia, the Israeli boats waited for new threats to emerge. The radar soon threw up another contact, a Syrian T-43 minesweeper to the northeast. This time *Reshef* peeled off to deal with her, hitting the ship with a Gabriel missile at a range of 11 miles (18 km). *Reshef* rejoined the main group, now coming within Styx missile range of Latakia.

At this point the Syrians responded in earnest. Three Syrian missile boats